The BRS chief says he is being targeted for rallying together political parties opposed to the BJP. He has already told party activists to be prepared for Kavitha's arrest by the Enforcement Directorate (ED), and will most likely use the 'wronged father and CM' appeal to ratchet up support and launch the campaign for the legislative assembly polls in Telangana due at the end of the year and the Lok Sabha election in 2024. The BRS is also trying to get together other political parties who have been 'victims' of the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and ED to buttress the accusations of the misuse of central agencies by the Modi government.

State rival Congress, though, is not one of them. Indeed, the party perceives the issue quite differently. Former Pradesh Congress Committee (PCC) president Ponnala Lakshmaiah wonders why there has been no movement on the ED investigation into "KCR's involvement in corruption cases" though the agency had questioned him back in 2017. He says the BJP's soft corner towards KCR is evident in the way he is being spared by agencies despite the huge corruption allegations against him. "Prime Minister Modi and Union home minister Amit Shah have repeatedly accused KCR of corruption in power purchase agreements, Mission Kakatiya and even called the Kaleshwaram lift irrigation project the 'chief minister's ATM'. But no action has been taken against him despite the evidence," he argues. He claims the ED probe against Kavitha is "a drama by the BJP as KCR is its trusted friend".

AGGRESSIVE STRATEGY

That may be the Congress pitch, but BRS itself has gone on full attack mode. Home minister Shah, who was in Hyderabad for the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) Raising Day celebrations on March 12, was greeted in the city by teaser hoardings for detergents with morphed images of tainted politicians across states who have "become clean" after defecting to the BJP. The message was clear—like washing powder cleans soiled clothes, corruption charges and scams disappear once the tainted politicians turned saffron.

KCR INTENDS TO USE THE 'WRONGED FATHER AND CM' APPEAL TO RATCHET UP SUPPORT FOR BRS

KCR, it seems, is determined to pull out all the stops in the BRS's campaign blitzkrieg in the run-up to the election. Carrying forward a successful electoral campaign from his last term, the party will conduct *athmeeya sammelanams* at the grassroots level with 10 gram panchayats or each municipality as a cluster. The party aims to complete the exercise ahead of its Foundation Day on April 27. BRS working president and KCR's son K.T. Rama Rao (KTR) reportedly told key activists during a teleconference on March 12 that the get-togethers were important to "infuse energy and create awareness among the 6 million plus party members".

The *athmeeya sammelanams* are events where sumptuous meals and beverages are arranged for all participants where it is not unknown for even party leaders to shake a leg to the tunes of popular Tollywood beats. Of course, the welfare schemes initiated by the BRS government will also be promoted at these dos. All elected representatives

VICTIM OR VILLAIN?

The ED says Kavitha brokered a liquor business deal for herself, AAP



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) alleges that KCR's daughter K. Kavitha and two others funneled money via hawala channels to the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) in Delhi to seal the South Group deal and get benefits from the state's new liquor policy. It also alleges that 30 per cent of Delhi's retail liquor business was controlled by the South Group, a cartel steered by them. WhatsApp chats between Kavitha's ex-auditor Gorantla Butchibabu, now out on bail, and other accused have multiple mentions of 'Madam' which, according to the ED, refers to Kavitha. In a February 23 statement, he told the ED that Rs 100 crore was funnelled through hawala as part of the deal with AAP communications in-charge Vijay Nair. Kavitha, who met Nair multiple times in Delhi and Hyderabad in 2021, was allegedly told that the excise policy would be swung in her favour in exchange for kickbacks. Kavitha, though, denies all the accusations. ''This is part of a malicious campaign to target the BRS, discredit our leader KCR and further the BJP's political interests,'' she says. The ED's remand report of Delhi deputy CM Manish Sisodia also mentions a ''deal between Kavitha and top AAP leaders''. She was reportedly offered stakes in partnership with Indospirits MD Sameer Mahendru and distribution rights of French wine brand Pernod Ricard. The CBI and ED allege that the liquor policy was modified to extend a high profit margin of 12 per cent to wholesalers and close to 185 per cent profit margin to retailers.